In her completed autobiography, from the dedication through the closing pages, Davis draws attention to physical and symbolic walls featured throughout the text, inviting readers to locate the author within structures of repression and networks of support. Again, this is recounted most significantly in the tales of her incarceration. Walls stand in for and/or resemble other structures that reference histories of struggle. They offer the very imaginative architecture of walls necessary to build solidarity, including the scene that takes place by the Berlin Wall. Davis uses the spatial metaphor of walls throughout the text to reengineer the terms for coalition building across boundaries and to illuminates the power of cross-border solidarity as "communities of struggle."

In Davis's first chapter, "Nets," she focuses on the three-month period when she was a fugitive and ultimately captured in New York City awaiting extradition to California. Her narrative begins with her furtive escape from U.S. authorities and then afterward moves back to a linear sense of time. The first appearance of a wall in the text, after the dedication page, is an exterior "red brick wall" of the New York Women's House of Detention. She remembers seeing this wall as a high school student in New York and recalls it in her narrative as both looming and "archaic." The exterior wall then portends her characterizations of the detestable conditions and basic rights in prisons, as well as attempts by officials to cordon off support for her from both outside and inside prison.[72] In the same chapter, as she describes being locked up in the prison's mental ward (because prison officials feared her influence in the general population), Davis uses the symbol of the wall to connote another disturbing division she encountered in this facility: "Each time I tried to help one [patient prisoner] out of misery, I would discover that a wall—far more impervious than the walls of our own cells—stood between us."[73] Davis writes of a hunger strike to call attention to the conditions of her imprisonment, focus her own energy, and match the growing support for her by those fighting for her freedom: "I would hold my own on this side of the walls while things got rolling on the other side."[74] Here, the symbol of the wall marks both her physical separation from social movements forming outside of prisons and a demarcation of psychological conditions inside. For Davis, the fortified prison walls were manifestations of larger circuits of repression.

In the chapters "Rocks," "Waters" (where she recalls her time in East and West Berlin), and "Flames," the narrative shifts back to her childhood and